

Compassion as appraisal, performative identity and moral affiliation

A corpus perspective and digital activist strategic communication analysis

Awni Etaywe

Charles Darwin University, Australia

This article addresses the underexplored topic of compassion in digital activism through linguistic research. Utilising corpus linguistics and the SFL appraisal framework, the study initially analyses the lemma “compassion” and its appraisal nature within The Coronavirus Corpus. It then models compassion development as a social discursive process, taking Boycott, Divestment and Sanctions (BDS-Australia) campaigns as a case study, drawing on “communion” and “tendering” strategies, and positioning theory-based morality by linking structure to agency. The analysis provides evidence that the concept of “compassion” extends beyond triggered emotions, expressing institutionalised feelings. Compassion also develops through a moral affiliation process: aligning identities, positioning others within shared moral and sociocultural frameworks, and exhorting people towards purposeful social actions as commodities. This research underscores compassion’s normative (i.e. moral orders) core and performative essence.

Keywords: compassion, peace, digital activism, moral affiliation, corpus linguistics, stance-taking, discourse of resistance, deviant persona, framing, identity processes

1. Introduction

The concept of “compassion” occupies a significant place within various academic domains such as health studies and the humanities and social sciences. However, research on how compassion is developed within digital activism remains scarce and the notion of compassion seems to carry different connotations across these domains despite its recurrent appearance. This paper contributes to research into

the multifaceted concept of compassion by seeking to elucidate the appraising nature of “compassion” and discern whether compassion’s essence is rooted more in emotion or morality and valuation. It explores the lemma “compassion” in the Coronavirus Corpus (explained in Section 3.1) and draws on the appraisal framework (Martin and White 2005), given the scarcity of linguistic investigations into compassion within the systemic functional linguistics tradition (hereafter SFL). Additionally, the study aims to linguistically describe how compassion is developed within digital activist discourse, taking the pro-Palestinian “Boycott, Divestment and Sanctions-Australia” (hereafter BDS-Australia) movement’s online campaigns as a case study, and describing it as a moral affiliation process within SFL (for more on morality in affiliation, see e.g. Etaywe and Zappavigna 2021, 2023; Etaywe 2022a, 2022b, 2023b).

Digital activism refers to a form of sociopolitical engagement that uses the internet and social media platforms for mass mobilisation and political action to bring about desirable social change (Fuentes 2023): for more on digital activism and social movements, see Carty (2010). This form of activism is regarded here as a form of strategic communication, that is a “purposeful use of communication by [the] organi[s]ation to fulfill its mission” (Hallahan et al. 2007:3), namely the mission of BDS-Australia which is part of a globally operating nonviolent anti-colonial resistance movement, BDS (Monshipouri and Prompichai 2017; CIVICUS 2022). The focus is on how BDS-Australia’s texts are designed to exhort people to perform acts that are in alignment with BDS’s aim, which is – as shared on its website, to: “end international support for Israeli violations of international law by forcing companies, institutions and governments to change their policies. As Israeli companies and institutions become isolated, Israel will find it more difficult to oppress Palestinians.”

Given the sense of common humanity and universal values, witnessing or learning about the experiences of the suffering of others arouses empathy and compassion for the plight of the vulnerable and shapes the level and pattern of our responses (Bandura 2016). Exhorted specific actions, after learning about such experiences, serve to construct these actions as acts of compassion. Considering empathy and compassion on a cline, empathy might be considered an emotional reaction (Bandura 2016) and perspective-taking (David 2016), while compassion extends beyond that temporary arousal to include the effort exerted in response to alleviate “the perceived suffering of others” (Bandura 2016:92). This study adopts this argument about compassion as being action-oriented (David 2016). It focuses on compassion in relation to the suffering of others (namely the Palestinians) (Tester 2001:18), given the recent rise of settlers’ attacks against Palestinians supported by the far-right Israeli government and its plan to double the settler population living illegally in the occupied Palestinian territories (United

Nations Human Rights Council 2023). The study highlights the role of language in raising awareness about the suffering of the Palestinian and in suggesting or exhorting people to respond in particular ways to “dreadful events, misery or suffering that we [might] stop noticing them” for being there for long and thus “we are left unmoved” (Tester 2001: 13). That is how language operates to counter two main challenges that the discourses of compassion encounter – ignorance and compassion fatigue (Höijer 2004).

By undertaking a necessary progressive discourse analysis (Martin 2004; Hughes 2018), the study contributes to a deeper understanding of compassion’s role in advocating for social change, while also aligning with UN Sustainable Development Goal 16 related to peace, equality and justice. BDS-Australia texts are taken as a positive, anti-apartheid resistant discourse produced as part of a non-violent tool for restoring justice and modelled after the South African anti-apartheid movement (Andrew 2022) and Nelson Mandela’s legacy of “compassion” and generosity (Miliband 2013). As put in Martin’s (1999: 51–52) words: “If discourse analysts are serious about wanting to use their work to enact social change, then they will have to broaden their coverage to include discourse of this kind – discourse that inspires, encourages, heartens...”

2. Literature review

Many studies have attempted to describe the process of compassion. For example, studies applying a social cognitive approach have modelled compassion as an act of moral reengagement that is based on rehumanising the relationship between members of conflicting parties (e.g. Bandura 2016). Other studies, drawing on organisational theory, have examined compassion in advertising and brand communication, shedding light on how brands enact compassion and self-presentation in COVID-19-related initiatives – suggesting a process of “noticing, feeling, and responding to human suffering in a coordinated manner” (e.g. Ertimur and Coskuner-Balli 2021: 230). Research into mental health argues that compassion is a practice encompassing three facets: the healthcare professional’s virtue, the establishment of a relational space and the patient’s response (Bond et al. 2022); the absence of this multifaceted compassionate experience may exacerbate mental health conditions, while its presence can foster hope and recovery. Compassion, as such, entails active responses to others’ hardships, ranging from individuals’ condemnations of injustices (e.g. practices of slavery, crimes against humanity) to international endeavours for democracy and justice (Höijer 2004; Bandura 2016). The literature, nevertheless, shows scarcity of linguistic research into the self-representation of performers of acts of compassion, and into the

linguistic modelling of compassion development. This study contributes to filling the latter gap.

A comprehensive review of the concept of “compassion” across different disciplines suggests that in the realm of politics, for example, compassion is considered a politically charged emotion and a potent political virtue that has its own political implications (Ure and Frost 2013). This perspective also presents compassion as a cornerstone of democratic societies, motivating individuals to safeguard others from harm and respond to their suffering (Nussbaum 2013). This view aligns with a broader sentiment conveyed by the religious context, where compassion is described as a profound emotion “for the troubles of another, accompanied by an *urge to help*” as in the command for charity, in Islam, to the poor (Swatos 1998: 112, emphasis added). Moreover, nursing researchers assert that compassion manifests both as a personal trait and a teachable behaviour (Bond et al. 2018). This meaning is emphasised in linguistic endeavours outside SFL looking at the meaning of the concept (e.g. Gladkova 2010). The present study builds on several dimensions of compassion that have emerged in the reviewed literature and seeks to establish linguistic evidence of them – including (i) that compassion is a trait or virtue, and (ii) that compassion develops as an action-oriented process and a participatory experience that involves learning about the suffering of others, the establishment of relational links and an urge for performance.

This study focuses on compassion in relation to the suffering of others and on compassion as a modern form of morality and an affirmation of humanity and human rights (Sznaider 2015). It argues for compassion as a process that involves generating the audience’s “desire and effort to alleviate the perceived suffering of others” (Bandura 2016: 92), and that compassionate acts are fuelled by moral beliefs and evaluations which, according to Campbell (2019[2003]), can account for the *desire* and the *motivation* to act. As such, in the digital context where texts are pregnant with moral evaluations (Zappavigna 2017), a functional approach to the morally evaluative language becomes crucial and enables us to see “how [evaluative] language is used: trying to find out what the purposes that language serves for [the activists] are, and how [they] are able to achieve these purposes through [texts]” (Halliday 1973: 7). This study posits that BDS-Australia activists’ use of evaluative language cultivates the desire and motives for acts of compassion and promotes them among activists, including the Australian “targeted imagined audience” (hereafter targeted audience) (Litt and Hargitta 2016). In addition, moral evaluations operate to legitimise particular social actions as appropriate or acceptable forms of “compassionate helping” (Faulkner 2013).

What is at stake when attempting to theorise and analyse the development of compassion, in digital activism as a process of moral affiliation, is:

- how digital texts call together communities “by both construing particular values and proposing particular orientations to attitudinal stances” (Zappavigna 2017: 451) and actions, and
- how the internet “provide[s] a space for alternative positionings to be heard and shared” (Caple and Bednarek 2020: 218).

This paper illuminates the nuances in the linguistic mechanisms for construing values, value-alignment and positioning through evaluative language, as an interpersonal meaning-making resource. That is a resource for enacting social relations, expressing attitudes and building “tenor” (Martin 2010).

The study aligns with previous SFL work on affiliation (e.g. Knight 2010; Zappavigna 2018; Etaywe and Zappavigna 2023). The key unit of affiliation analysis is the “coupling” of ideational and attitudinal meaning, where coupling is the linguistic realisation of a social bond (examples and further explanation are provided in the method section – Section 3). According to this perspective, bonds are mobilised in discourse (e.g. by being shared, rejected or deferred), attempting to align language users into communities of shared values. In this way the act of “bonding” is concerned with “ways of building togetherness, inclusiveness and affiliation” (Stenglin 2004: 402) and the construction of “overlapping communities of attitudinal rapport” (Martin 2004: 323).

To account for morality in discourse, this study adopts Van Langenhove’s (2017) perspective of morality linking social structure to individual and collective moral agency and discourse activation of cultural, legal and institutional moral orders as shared moral fields. Once these fields are activated in discourse:

- they become sites for value-(re)alignment.
- the morally motivated acts of help allow for a performative identity (Butler 2021) to emerge from these social and semiotic practices (Bucholtz and Hall 2005).
- we come to appreciate the moral foundations for the social process, institutional activity and the audience’s participation in life and social processes (Martin 2010).

Taking note of how the activists and targeted audience are positioned in relation to socially recognised stances towards these moral fields also enables further insight into constructed activist-audience shared values, relations and expectations and hence “a more fine-grained means of tracking the construal of [e.g. morally deviant] textual persona(e)” (Don 2017: 70). By focusing on these values activated in digital activists, “we can conceive of persona aligning themselves into sub-cultures, configuring master identities and constituting a culture” (Martin 2010: 24).

3. Method

3.1 Data: The Coronavirus corpus and the BDS-Australia campaigns

To investigate the appraising nature of the concept of “compassion” and to establish evidence of its action-oriented and ethics-based nature (a basis for the second part of the study – i.e. affiliation analysis), the Coronavirus Corpus was used. This corpus was chosen given the increased demand for care and compassion during the COVID-19 period, making the corpus a suitable platform to explore how the lemma “compassion*” is employed. This corpus, containing approximately 1.5 billion words across 1.9 million texts, captures the socio-cultural and economic impact of the COVID-19 pandemic from January 2020 to December 2022. The texts were collected from online magazines and newspapers in 20 different English-speaking countries. The corpus’s size during the study was 1.4 billion words.

Beyond the analysis of the lemma “compassion*” and in a step towards exploring and theorising compassion development in digital discourse, the primary dataset explored has comprised Facebook posts from the BDS-Australia Facebook page (encompassing hyperlinks) and the landing webpages to which these hyperlinks lead. The choice of this movement was motivated by the fact it is connected to a century-long anti-colonial resistance that has gone digital since 2005. The analysis of these digital texts focuses on language use, namely in the most recent texts (at the time of this study) in three of the most persistent campaigns:

- “Boycott Puma” – the Facebook posts shared in May 2023 and the webpages accessed through the hyperlinks.
- “Don’t buy HP” – the May 2023 posts and linked webpages.
- “Stop Elbit” – the August 2022 posts and associated webpages.

These campaigns give a representation of:

- boycotting campaigns, which generally encompass academic, economic, and cultural boycotts, targeting Israel’s universities, cultural institutions, and companies involved in international trade.
- divestment campaigns that target financiers, businesses and universities investing in Israel.
- sanctions campaigns that aim to pressure governments to oppose Israeli apartheid and violations of international law.

Regarding the broader context of these campaigns, BDS activist discourse advocates against Israel’s colonialist settlements and apartheid and thus echoes the

morality and “truth” statements of BDS (Andrews 2022). This moral stance is legitimised, endorsed and supported by United Nations experts and human rights organisations’ reports, like Human Rights Watch’s (hereafter HRW) “a threshold crossed” and Amnesty International’s (HRW 2021), and by Israeli and Jewish groups like Jewish Voice for Peace Rabbinic Council’s report on “Israeli apartheid” (Jewish Voice for Peace 2022). For example, HRW affirms that Israel governs most areas, including “Occupied Palestinian Territory” (OPT), the latter made up of the West Bank, including East Jerusalem, and the Gaza Strip, maintaining “Jewish Israeli control over demographics, political power, and land”, and “subjugate[ing] Palestinians by virtue of their identity to varying degrees of intensity” that reach the extent of crimes against humanity like apartheid and persecution (HRW 2021: np). In addition, United Nations Special Rapporteur Michael Lynk underscores Israel’s unlawful practices, meeting apartheid’s definition:

Apartheid is not, sadly, a phenomenon confined to the history books on southern Africa [...] For more than 40 years, *the UN Security Council and General Assembly have stated in hundreds of resolutions that Israel’s annexation of occupied territory is unlawful*, its construction of hundreds of Jewish settlements [is] illegal, and its denial of Palestinian self-determination breaches international law.

(United Nations News 2022: np, emphasis in original)

BDS-Australia discourse is part of this global context and operates to gather communal support and engagement to end support for Israel’s oppression of Palestinians. According to the BDS-Australia website, BDS-Australia networks with various pro-Palestine associations and individuals aiming to inform the Australian community about events in occupied Palestinian territories, and to challenge national and international support for Israeli apartheid. Australian society’s struggle for indigenous rights also draws parallels with the Palestinians’ situation.

3.2 Data analysis procedure

3.2.1 *A corpus-informed analysis of the concept of “compassion”*

A corpus analysis of the concept of “compassion” was undertaken to uncover its evaluative nature and explore its linguistic usage patterns (for more about the context of the use of this concept, refer to Section 3.1, paragraph 1). This approach is empirical, relying on a systematic collection of authentic texts, computerised analysis, and both qualitative and quantitative techniques (Biber et al. 1998; McEnery and Hardie 2011). The analysis focused on the frequency analysis of the lemma “compassion*” and its collocates within The Coronavirus Corpus concordance lines. Initially, the frequency of the lemma’s usage was identified.

Recognising the interconnectedness of lexis and grammar (Biber et al. 1999), the statistical analysis included the parts of speech associated with the lemma and was exemplified by the first 200 concordance lines.

To delve into the semantic significance and explore collocations with “compassion*”, a thorough collocation analysis – the statistical tendency of a word to co-occur (e.g. Sinclair 1991) – was then performed to (i) ascertain statistically probable associations between “compassion” and other words, and (ii) shed light on the nuanced meaning and usage of the term, including the discourse surrounding the lemma and polarity-bearing words found in its proximity. A contextual examination of the lemma was pursued to unravel its function as an attitudinally charged word or an ideational catalyst for attitudinal responses. Using the keyword-in-context (KWIC) corpus method, this examination focused on the lemma’s immediate textual context of the first 200 concordance lines. To provide a systematic description of potential verbal expressions associated with the lemma, it was categorised into the three regions of “ways of feeling” or attitudinal meanings (Martin and White 2005: 42):

- JUDGEMENT: assessments of behaviour, which serve to propose rules and regulations.
- APPRECIATION: estimating the value of entities or processes, which serves as propositions about criteria and value.
- AFFECT: expressing emotional reactions and states

3.2.2 *A moral affiliation analysis of compassion development*

In this case study focusing on the online BDS campaigns (for more about the context, see Section 3.1, paragraphs 2–4), the investigation into how BDS-Australia’s activists cultivate compassion through moral value-alignment with their audience and promote specific actions is undertaken using a “moral affiliation” analysis. Rooted in the affiliation framework within SFL, this approach (Knight 2010) focuses on understanding how meanings are constructed in functional contexts, particularly in addressing social issues and inequalities (Halliday 2008). The primary analytical unit employed for probing how meanings and values – taken as interpersonal bonds in terms of the social relations and identities that meanings and values enact (Zappavigna 2014) – are negotiated in texts is evaluative couplings, combining ideational meanings with attitudinal meanings (Knight 2010). These couplings enable audiences to co-identify discursively, forming a minimal social unit or bond that serves to construct community alignment, as exemplified in:

PUMA is complicit in Israel’s apartheid regime.

In this instance, the negative attitude (a feature of JUDGEMENT, underlined) is directed at Puma (ideation, in bold), expressing condemnation and disalignment with Puma's support for apartheid. This coupling expresses an attitude in discourse which we might gloss as "supporting apartheid is bad". This bond's fusion of ideational and attitudinal meaning can be visually depicted using the yin-yang symbol (Figure 1) (e.g. Etaywe and Zappavigna 2023).

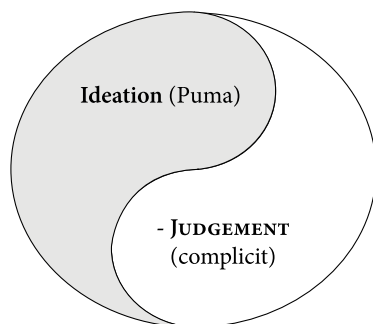


Figure 1. Visual representation of a bond

After identification of all couplings and instances of ideational meaning invoking attitude (mainly the use of attitudinally fused terms e.g. "freedom", "apartheid") in the three campaigns, the couplings were categorised into patterns or axiological constellations (for a similar analysis, see Doran 2019), describing: the key bonds, linguistic resources used, and their function – that is whether aligning with positively charged ideational meanings or disaligning with negatively charged ideational meanings. Negative bonds are glossed as acts of condemnation of "bad" actions positioning them as rejected and unshareable, while positive bonds position actions as accepted and shareable.

Given that evaluations and beliefs can account for the desire and the motivation to act on a moral basis (Campbell 2003[2019]), and they come in response to a disruption in a moral order (Etaywe 2022b), the couplings were also described in terms of patterns of their underpinning moral orders. This study used Van Langenhove's (2017) positioning theory-based framework of broad moral orders – legal, cultural and institutional moral orders – to offer an interpretive lens on the activated moral fields in discourse and how they shape evaluative processes that can motivate and influence how audiences act in society (for more on this influence, see e.g. Kádár and Parvaresh 2019). For example, the JUDGEMENT-based bond denouncing Puma's complicity above is underpinned by assumptions about the rule of law (namely, the Apartheid Convention and the Rome Statute) and the liberty/oppression meta-value that enables us to see evaluative acts as a reflection of resistance to restrictions on others' right to freedom (for a similar argu-

ment, see Etaywe 2022b, 2023b). Based on this argument, the bond can be glossed as: “supporting apartheid is bad: immoral/illegal”. Bonds were also described in terms of the moral frames activated (e.g. frame of injustice) for mobilisation purposes (e.g. Benford and Snow 2000). This study argues for “knowledge schemas” framing, which is a form of framing that accounts for shared assumptions and moral expectations about the world, people, events, humanity and so on (Gordon and Tannen 2023), and for the role of information shared by BDS-Australia in providing “definitions of a situation” (Goffman 1974: 10). That is, in terms of the analysis undertaken, social frames are taken as a context for identity construction work (Coupland 2007), namely shaping the compassionate identity, and as basis for the arousal of compassion and associated responses (as exemplified and detailed in Section 4.2.1). Mapping the enacted values within these frames allows for tracking the construal of textual persona – that is, who are constructed as or on the side of victims, helpers and anti-colonialist, or the side of victimisers and “pro-colonialists”.

For all couplings, tactics of the “communion affiliation” strategy (Etaywe and Zappavigna 2023) used in the campaigns were then identified and described, that is, in terms of how couplings operate to forge solidarity, consensus and shared moral field membership. This analysis enables seeing the categorisation of these tactics. The following principles and complementary forms of linguistic analysis were conducted, aimed at unpacking interpersonal meaning and identity construction (Bucholtz 2003; Bucholtz and Hall 2005):

- The principle of indexicality: whereby identity is constructed by indexes such as names or labels as interpersonally charged ideational meanings that provoke attitude.
- The principle of relationality: whereby identity is intersubjectively constructed through relations between ideational meanings such as similarity/difference, or between people and their actions as acts of authenticity or genuineness/artifice and (de)legitimacy.
- The principle of positionality: whereby identities encompass specific demographic categories, cultural positions; and stances and participant roles.

To understand how texts operate to position the targeted audiences (i.e. Australians) and exhort them towards purposeful action, the analysis included the linguistic strategies used to position others to respond, to do something or to say something, known in pragmatics as the “illocutionary point” of utterances (Searle 1999). Focus on positioning and the moral epistemic status of the activists or author aids in understanding the pragmatic function of the utterances in relation to the strategic aim of BDS-Australia. The moral epistemic status of the author is “a critical resource for determining the status of the utterance as an

action” or directive and command-like (Heritage 2012: 7; Etaywe 2022a). Drawing on Doran, Martin and Zappavigna’s (2024) “tendering” principle that builds on the speech function notion (Halliday and Matthiessen 2014: 136) – in terms of characterising exchanges of, or dealing with, goods and services (and actions) as proposals and dealing with information as propositions – texts that include the evaluative couplings and function to position the audiences were categorised into two tactics:

- tendering proposals: This involves presenting demands or actions for negotiation and seeking a response. The purposes of proposed actions were further categorised as goal-, means- or effect-oriented (van Leeuwen 2008) to argue for how these actions align with BDS-Australia’s mission.
- tendering propositions: This tactic concerns providing information that enhances the credibility of exhorted actions in the eyes of the audience.

4. Results and discussion

4.1 The corpus-based exploration of the lemma “compassion”

The corpus-based analysis of the lemma “compassion*” has yielded insights into its nuanced usage. The analysis revealed that this lemma appeared 29,371 times (see Figure 2), with “compassion” being the most frequent variant (56.6%), followed by “compassionate” (41.39%) and “compassionately” (1.20%). These variants show that the lemma primarily manifests as a noun (to name or represent a thing or activity, quality, or idea) and an adjective (as a modifier that describes or attributes quality to a noun (e.g. “leave”, “use” and “ground”), thereby focusing the concordance and collocation analysis on these forms.

When delving into the lemma’s linguistic context, its collocates – i.e. “the company it keeps” (Firth 1957: 11) – also provide a nuanced view of its meaning. The repeated associations with words like “care”, “empathy”, “love” and “kind*” (see lines 1, 2, 5 and 6, Figure 3) indicate the lemma’s positive polarity and valued nature. These “attitudinal inscriptions” (White 2006) portray it as something cherished. Additionally, “show” and “lack” (lines 8 and 9) collocating with “compassion” reveal that compassion is both something that can be embodied or demonstrated and a trait that can be possessed or lacked – proving support to Bond et al.’s (2018) similar argument (outlined in Section 2).

To elaborate on the idea that compassion is a demeanour or behavioural disposition we can possess or lack, consider examples (1)–(3). Structures like “lack of” and “have no” express compassion’s absence (Example (1)), while “with large reserves of + compassion”, “possessive pronouns + compassion” and “have” convey



Figure 2. The most frequent lexical variants of lemma “compassion*”

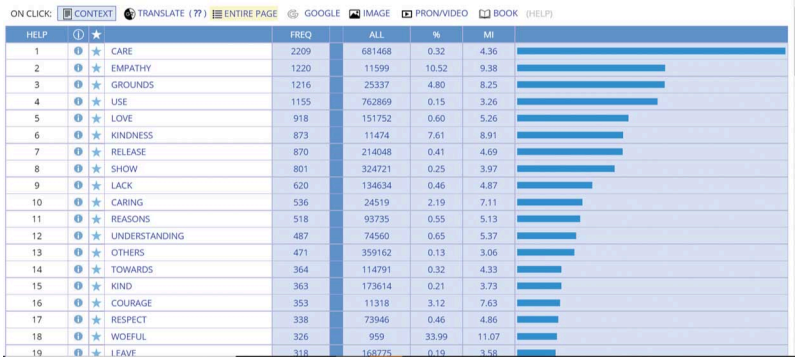


Figure 3. Meanings taken on by the lemma “compassion*”

possession (Example (2)). Furthermore, “show+compassion” (Example (3)) emphasises compassion as something demonstrable or can be achieved by means of another action, as realised in “do more” (underlined) which serves to construct the act of doing as a purposeful social action (cf. van Leeuwen 2008) realised in the “to” phrase (in bold). In other words, the value of compassion appears to be reachable by performing. Other structures like “see+compassion” and “mobilise+compassion” also present compassion as tangible, exchangeable and performative, and as a “commodity” (Halliday and Matthiessen 2014) – a concept revisited in the next section.

- (1) AMC said that the lack of compassion by the government towards the health care workers is...
- (2) Their dedication and compassion is unmatched.
- (3) He thought the State could do more to show compassion and empathy in relation to issuing vaccine...

The lemma's predominant use as an attitude or ideational meaning invoking an attitudinal response is noteworthy as it has been found to serve as a tool for:

- Judgement: describing people, their actions and tendencies toward others (Example (4)), emphasising compassion's performative nature, its link to effort and being ethics-charged.
 - (4) She is a very compassionate and patriotic individual.
- Appreciation: describing concepts, values, events, processes, entities, and products, portraying compassion as a criterion of valuation (see Example (5) where the needed "approach" is described as being "compassionate").
 - (5) We need the same compassionate, yet commonsense approach.

These findings highlight compassion as a conduit to shared community values, transcending our everyday emotional understanding into the realm of shared community values, or "institutionalised feelings" (Martin and White 2005: 45) about what makes, for example, a good individual (Example (4)) or way of doing things (Example (5)). That is, on the one hand, using "compassion" in judgement, as an ethical and moral proposal, adds depth to the lemma's meaning, offering guidance on behaviour and/or how one should act. The appreciation aspect, on the other hand, portrays the use of the lemma as a transformation of feelings into propositions about value (of e.g. an approach needed to address COVID-19 related situations), formalised through criteria and assessment. In brief, the analysis in this section has set the stage for further exploration, in the next section, of formalised moral frameworks that drive the performance of acts of compassion, and the development of compassion as identity work that involves tangible (i.e. demonstrable) performance and attainable outcomes through various social actions.

4.2 Moral affiliation: Activating a moral order, forging alignment, positioning and exhortation

The analysis of communication strategies by BDS-Australia activists revealed a constant negotiation of values within the communion affiliation strategy aimed at fostering compassion. Immoral bonds emerged, contrasting with established social moral bonds. This section presents findings, key bonds and their function in activating specific moral frameworks to create a shared moral order (Section 4.2.1). The section delves into communion affiliation tactics aligning values and identity with readers to promote compassionate actions (Section 4.2.2). Lastly, it examines the positioning of readers to perform compassionate actions and the intended social purposes of these performances (Section 4.2.3).

4.2.1 *Patterns of collocative values, key bonds and an activated moral order*

The examination revealed the construction of a dichotomy of moral anti-colonialists versus immoral pro-colonialists' personae. This construction is realised by repeatedly coupling targeted entities (e.g. Puma, RMIT and Australian entities, HP) with negative ATTITUDE and associating activists and audiences with positive ATTITUDE. This construction also gives rise to negatively charged ideational meanings "acting as loci of moral valuations" (Tann 2010:175) and an embodiment of disruption of moral fields existing at the collective and public level – hence an invitation to take sides. The BDS texts have predominantly employed JUDGEMENT-based couplings, including APPRECIATION-based couplings that invoke negative JUDGEMENT. This linguistic pattern serves to align with the victims and activists, to disalign from the immoral acts of targeted entities and to activate a framework of moral fields to defend – namely legal, cultural and institutional moral fields. See Table 1 for an example account of the linguistic resources used for moral (dis)alignment, and the activated moral fields.

Table 1 exemplifies the linguistic resources used in the three campaigns, their functions, and the moral underpinnings of the evaluative couplings – rows 1–6 in the table correspond respectively with examples (6)–(11) below. Example (6) employs a negative JUDGEMENT-based coupling to disalign with Puma, positioning the brand as supporting illegal Israeli settlements through supporting the Israel Football Association "on land stolen from Palestinians" (underlined). In contrast, positive JUDGEMENT in example (7) aligns with BDS-Australia, indicating alignment with those advocating for ending complicity – people "of conscience" (underlined). Similar linguistic resources and functions were observed in the "Stop Elbit" and "Don't Buy HP" campaigns, illustrating consistent strategies in using evaluative couplings to establish moral alignment with

Table 1. Examples of the linguistic resources, functions and moral fields in BDS campaigns

Campaign	Row	Linguistic resources	Couplings	Function	Moral fields
Boycott Puma	1	Negative JUDGEMENT-based coupling	[Puma/ supports the Israel Football Association operating in illegal settlements]	Disaligning with (negatively charged) Puma	Legal moral order: international law
	2	Positive JUDGEMENT-based coupling	[Palestinians and people of conscience around the world/ are calling on PUMA to end its complicity]	Aligning with (positively charged) BDS Australia	
Stop Elbit	3	Negative JUDGEMENT-based coupling	[RMIT's Collaboration with Israel weapons manufacturers like Elbit/ disgrace]	Disaligning with (negatively charged) RMIT	Legal moral order: international law Cultural moral order: harm/ care
	4	Positive JUDGEMENT-based coupling	[BDS Australia/ condemns the Victorian state and Federal government's and RMIT University's collaboration in Elbit]	Aligning with (positively charged) BDS Australia	Legal moral order: international law Institutional moral order
Don't Buy HP	5	Negative JUDGEMENT-based coupling	[HP/ complicit in the crime of apartheid]	Disaligning with (negatively charged) HP	Legal moral order: international law (Apartheid)

Table 1. (continued)

Campaign	Row	Linguistic resources	Couplings	Function	Moral fields
	6	Positive JUDGEMENT-based coupling	[We/call for mass boycotts of HPE... to end their complicity in Israeli apartheid]	Aligning with (positively charged) BDS Australia	Convention and the Rome Statute)

BDS and its supporters (see examples 7, 9 and 11 with judgements underlined, and rows 2, 4, and 6 in Table 1 respectively) or disalignment with targeted entities (see examples 6, 8 and 10 with judgements underlined, and rows 1, 3 and 5 in Table 1). In Example (8), the negatively judged RMIT university for its collaboration with Israeli weapons manufacturers like Elbit is positioned as an immoral institution for contributing to research serving aggression against the Palestinians. This involvement disrupts shared cultural moral orders, namely the liberty/oppression and care/harm meta-values. In addition, by collaborating with the Israeli army's development of weapons systems targeting the Palestinians, RMIT is positioned as participating in this anti-international legal moral order pertinent to war crimes.

- (6) **The Israel Football Association** operates in illegal Israeli settlements, on land stolen from Palestinians, and **Puma supports this association...**
- (7) **Palestinians and people of conscience around the world** are calling on PUMA to end its complicity.
- (8) Collaborating with weapons manufacturers like Elbit – Israel's huge arms manufacturer is a disgrace to **RMIT Melbourne City-Australia.**
- (9) **BDS Australia** condemns the Victorian state and Federal government and RMIT University's collaboration with Elbit Systems and Elbit Systems of Australia and calls on all Australians to oppose and take action to stop arms deals and any research and training agreements with Elbit.
- (10) International companies involved with Israel's illegal settlements are complicit in the crime of apartheid. **HP, Hewlett Packard Enterprise... THIS MEANS YOU!**
- (11) **We reiterate our** call for mass boycotts of HPE and HP Inc. until they end their complicity in Israeli apartheid and war crimes.

The account of “collocative values” (Etaywe 2022b, 2023b) in the “Don’t buy HP” campaign, for example, also reflects a prosodic structure resulting from the unfolding of “bad HP” – which is, for example, “complicit in the crime of apartheid” (Example (10)) – versus “good BDS Australia” (negative-positive) values. Hence it provides insights into the unfolding categories of moralised activism versus immoral HP’s acts. Activated as a cluster in opposition to HP actions, positive values collocating with BDS-Australia (who act to end HP complicity, as in Example (11)) within the framework of legal moral order (e.g. international law) serves to construct BDS-Australia and its urged boycott actions as being: *“the only moral stand to take in the face of Israel’s [...] violations of Palestinian human rights”*.

The coupling patterns in these campaigns activated a set of key bonds at stake (see Figures 4–6), meaning that identifiable patterns of assumptions, perspectives and moral foundations were relatively stable in the three campaigns. The moral fields underpinning these couplings emphasise that these moral grounds are activated at the same time as “both a background to people as well as a consequence of [people’s communication and agency]” (Van Langenhove 2017: 8). In addition, the enactment of these moral bonds has the rhetorical power to “both limit [...] what people [and entities] can say and do as well as it opens possibilities for saying and doing certain things” (Van Langenhove 2017: 8) in support of those in distress.

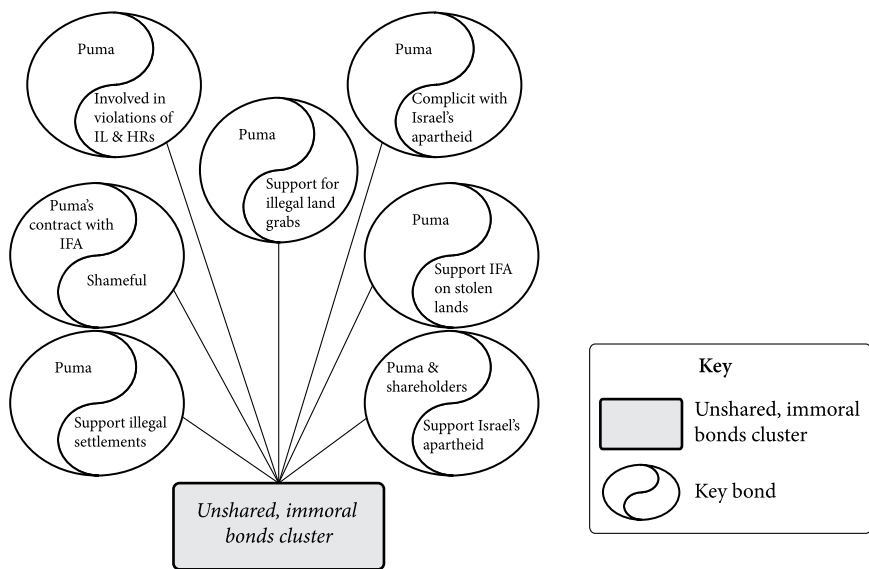


Figure 4. A summary of the key bonds in the “Boycott Puma” campaign

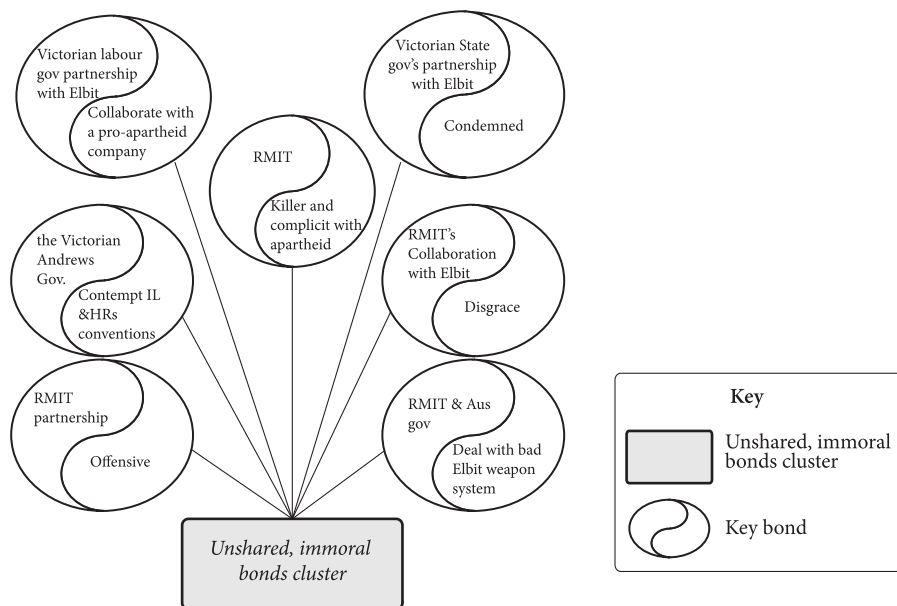


Figure 5. A summary of the key bonds in the "Stop Elbit" campaign

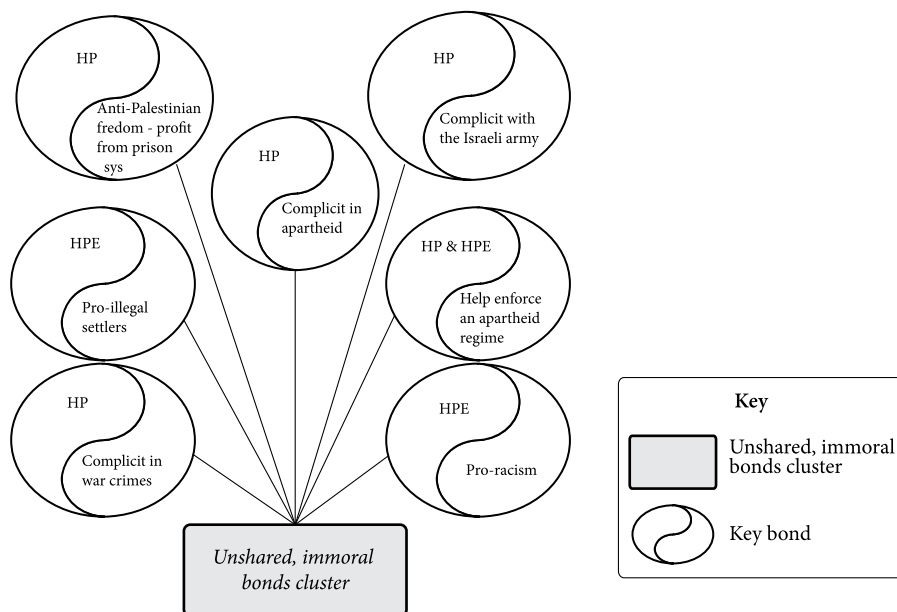


Figure 6. A summary of the key bonds in the "Don't buy HP" campaign

By enacting bonding, through tabling the key bonds, BDS-Australia distances itself and its supporters from entities like Puma, RMIT and HP, while fostering solidarity and inclusiveness through creating an attitudinal rapport and a rational concern for human suffering. For example, the “Puma is complicit in apartheid” and “Puma supports illegal settlements” bonds are used to position these entities as morally opposed to universal values of justice and equality, contrasting Puma’s “claims” of “devotion to universal equality” (Example (12)). Similar bonds are enacted in relation to HP as a business involved in “illegal settlements enterprise” (Example (13)) and the Victorian Andrews government, framing it as contemptuous of international law and human rights conventions by partnering with Elbit – a company linked to Israeli government practices perceived as apartheid (Example (14)). By constantly tabling these bonds, BDS-Australia creates frames of contested values which, while contested within the Israeli-Palestinian context, are condemned worldwide, such as occupation, apartheid, war crimes and racial discrimination as a frame of reference to differentiate between victims and victimisers. The repetition of the key bonds against these frames of reference is a strategic “frame amplification” process (Benford and Snow 2000: 623) that:

- makes certain experiences and ideas (e.g. killing, stealing and imprisonment) in the Palestinian context more salient.
- serves to assign responsibility (for complicity) and establishes a moral rationale for involvement in the BDS activism – that is the “diagnostic framing” and “motivational framing” tasks respectively (cf. Benford and Snow 2000) by construing the people and entities as violators of shared moral orders and hence morally deviant personae.

- (12) **PUMA** claims it has a “devotion to universal equality.” That can’t be true as long as **PUMA** is complicit in Israel’s apartheid regime.

[Puma/ – JUDGEMENT]

- (13) 112 companies are included in the **United Nations database** of companies involved in apartheid Israel’s illegal settlements enterprise.

[HP/ – JUDGEMENT]

- (14) In partnering with Elbit, **the Victorian Andrews government** is showing its contempt for international law and human rights conventions.

[the Victorian government/ – JUDGEMENT]

Overall, tabling the key bonds operates to shape a collective identity and sense of belonging among BDS-Australia and its target audience. The next section expands on the affiliation tactics used for forging this alignment around shared identity and collective bonds.

4.2.2 Value alignment: Communion affiliation tactics

This section explains the communion affiliation tactics, elucidating the linguistic resources employed by BDS-Australia to foster alignment and a social network. These tactics revolve around attitudinal resources, employed to establish a sense of shared identity with potential supporters and demarcate distinctions from the targeted “pro-colonialists”.

4.2.2.1 Attitudinal expansion tactic

“Attitudinal expansion” (Etaywe and Zappavigna 2023:11) is used across campaigns and operates by deploying sequences of ideation-attitude couplings that reinforce a key bond. This method is enacted through two key tactics: attitudinal “enhancement” (Zhao 2020) and “elaboration” (Etaywe and Zappavigna 2023). Enhancement here operates by amplifying an ATTITUDE by presenting additional instances of the same ATTITUDE type and polarity, aimed at ideational targets that share similarities with or distinctions from BDS-Australia. For instance, in Example (15), BDS-A utilises attitudinal expansion to reinforce the views presented in Example (13) (above). The coupling of Puma with a negative JUDGEMENT emphasises Puma’s alignment with Israel’s apartheid practices, hence negative values. By supporting apartheid, Puma’s identity is constructed as being “*unlike other sports brands which have refused to support Israel’s illegal settlements and ongoing persecution of Palestinians*”.

- (15) **The Israel Football Association operates in illegal Israeli settlements, on land stolen from Palestinians and Puma supports this association.**

[Puma/ – JUDGEMENT]

Elaborating involves specifying or clarifying an ideation or ATTITUDE. In Example (16) (where expressions of APPRECIATION are underlined), BDS-Australia elaborates on the collaboration between RMIT and Israel’s army by clarifying the kind of complicity – that is symbolised by the development of Elbit weapon systems. Elbit is used in war crimes and human rights violations. The negative APPRECIATION-based couplings also specify what is bad about Elbit and construct RMIT and the Australian government as agents of immoral actions collaborating with Israel’s army and having Elbit “*field tested*” on the Palestinians, promoting disalignment with the named target which in turn disaligns anyone who identifies with them – and ultimately aligning the audience with BDS-Australia’s stance. Since these campaigns are used by and for activists, the series of couplings such as these promote activists’ actions as rational responses to illegal weapon systems used for surveillance, arbitrary arrest of Palestinians and offensive operations.

- (16) a. **Elbit Systems** is Israel's largest privately-owned arms and security company which produces 85 percent of the drones and land-based equipment used by the Israeli military.
- b. **Elbit Systems** is the subject of international condemnation and divestment due to its complicity with Israel's severe violations of international law and human rights conventions.
- c. **Elbit drones** are also used for surveillance throughout Gaza, the Occupied Palestinian Territories and East Jerusalem supporting the arbitrary arrest and imprisonment of civilians and the curtailment of freedom of movement throughout Jerusalem and the Occupied Territories.

4.2.2.2 *Iconisation tactic*

The iconisation tactic is employed across the three campaigns to forge alignment, based on compliance with international norms and universal values, by leveraging “bonding icons” (Stenglin 2004: 402) which crystallise shared attitudes and values, using symbolic entities and objects (Knight 2008). These include the “United Nations” (which symbolises international norms and organised work to build and maintain peace, security, justice and equality), “Geneva Conventions” (that symbolises international treaties and protocols that establish international legal standards for humanitarian treatment in armed conflict zones), International Court of Justice and the “separation wall”. For example, in campaigning against Elbit, the Australian government and RMIT are constructed as violators by developing Elbit systems, violating “Geneva Conventions”. Additionally, the “condemned” “separation wall”, constructed by the Israeli authorities throughout the Palestinian cities and villages, is used to symbolise policies that RMIT-developed technology is supporting (Example (17)), including policies of apartheid, dispossession of lands, restriction on Palestinians’ movements and obstructing a two-independent states solution. These icons, thus, distil interpersonal meanings with which the targeted audience can co-identify or differentiate from and reject.

- (17) Elbit provides electronics for the ‘**separation wall**’ which was deemed illegal by the **International Court of Justice** in July 2004 and which supports Israel's apartheid policies which have been condemned by Israel's most prominent NGO B'tselem.

4.2.2.3 *Indexical labelling tactic*

The indexical labelling tactic is employed in the three campaigns where interpersonally charged ideational meanings are employed to provoke attitude and forge value alignment and identity relations via overtly mentioning identity labels, linguistic structures associated with specific personas, and “implicatures and

presuppositions regarding one's own or others' identity position" (cf. Bucholtz and Hall 2005:594). Example (18) utilises indexical labelling, using the term "apartheid" – that alludes to the related legal conventions (e.g. Apartheid Convention) and to the crimes committed under this historical discriminatory system in South Africa– to draw attention to RMIT's negative attitude while constructing its "killer" persona. The use of such indexes enables the establishment of semiotic links between linguistic structure and social meanings and assumptions rooted in shared historical and cultural beliefs for mobilisation purposes.

- (18) ...by continuing the partnership with Elbit, RMIT is complicit with Israel's apartheid and has blood on its hands.

4.2.2.4 *Attitudinal adequation tactic*

The adequation (equation+adequacy) tactic is based on the principle of relationality whereby identity is constructed through relations established between two ideational targets (Bucholtz 2003) and is employed in the "Boycott Puma" and "Don't buy HP" campaigns to emphasise the similarity between positively or negatively viewed ideational targets. This tactic accentuates shared values to align with BDS-Australia, Palestinians and the targeted audience, as in Example (19) where a shared sense "of conscience" is accentuated to create some shared commonality across the lines of difference that separate individuals nationally and across borders. BDS-Australia here does not seek to erase those differences but to accentuate human and universal similarities that dictate "calling on PUMA to end its complicity" (underlined). Stressing similarities between negatively charged ideational meanings to differentiate from the targeted entities, Example (20) juxtaposes HP's profit from apartheid practices with Polaroid's profit and complicity in South Africa's apartheid (underlined).

- (19) Palestinians and people of conscience around the world are calling on PUMA to end its complicity.
- (20) HP companies profit from all aspects of Israel's apartheid. Their role is similar to Polaroid's complicity with South Africa during apartheid... HP is the "Polaroid of our time".

4.2.2.5 *Illegitimation tactic*

The illegitimation tactic is based on Bucholtz and Hall's (2005) principle of relationality between ideational targets and actions and is used in the "Boycott Puma" campaign as a differentiation process by reference to specific moral values to serve to deny a claim or imparting of a recognised status of the brand. Example (21) uses negative evaluative expressions (namely, "claim", "can't be true" and "is complicit in Israel's apartheid crimes") whereby BDS-Australia distances Puma's claim of

“devotion to universal equality” thus challenging its legitimacy as an impartial sports partner. By this tactic, BDS-Australia negates Puma’s claim and asserts its complicity in Israel’s apartheid regime and allows for identity relations to emerge and for differential values and corrective actions to Puma’s role to be negotiated – Puma: “*should be bringing people together*” not to “*support apartheid Israel’s grave human rights abuses against Palestinians*”.

- (21) PUMA claims [Puma/ – JUDGEMENT] it has a “devotion to universal equality.” That can’t be true [That (Puma’s claim)/ – APPRECIATION] as long as PUMA is complicit in Israel’s apartheid regime [Puma/ – JUDGEMENT].

To provide evidence of the discrepancy between Puma’s claim and “reality”, BDS-Australia presents an account of verifiable historical events that are constructed as acts that “*occur with Puma’s complicity*” and where Puma cares only for profit and shows no care for the killing of Palestinian footballers. For example, “[o]n May 5, 2021 [and on] May 11, 2022, the very same day[s] that PUMA shareholders met to discuss profits, Israeli soldiers shot and killed 16-year-old Palestinian [footballers]”. Across the three campaigns, BDS-Australia tends to establish authenticity in its communication to mobilise support for its cause, by presenting these verifiable events chiefly via providing hyperlinks to credible sources (e.g. Amnesty International’s report on Israel’s actions against Palestinians) and independent research centres.

This use of information and third-party sources enhances BDS-Australia’s credibility and authenticity. The concept of authenticity adopted here is in its sociolinguistic meaning. That is, the systematic use of language by BDS-Australia reflects genuine people in real contexts, language that can be verified, and language encoding facts and truths (Bucholtz 2003: 398; Coupland 2003: 421). The authenticity of the imagined audience is taken here as an effect of the tactic of *attitudinal authentication* – which is based on the principle of relationality between ideational targets and actions (Bucholtz 2003) – that produces the audience’s compassionate identity. Positioning others through proposals, which is explained in the next section, is part of the ongoing process of *authentication*, whereby one’s performance emphasises their genuine or credible identity. BDS-Australia positions its audience by urging them to take specific actions, like boycotting certain entities. Failure to align with “the constantly negotiated social practices [of compassion]” and values can result in one’s identity (or a claimed compassionate identity) being labelled as inauthentic (Bucholtz 2003: 407). Overall, BDS-Australia strategically employs language and information to authenticate its cause and authenticate others’ identities in relation to the Palestinians’ suffering, mobilising support and fostering a compassionate identity among its audience where “EVERY ACTION IS IMPORTANT” (as emphasised in the “Boycott Puma” campaign).

The next section reports the tactics used to position the targeted audience in relation to the various exhorted actions as well as the discursive construction of the purpose of these actions.

4.2.3 *Positioning others and exhortation of purposeful action*

The examination of the three campaigns shows a consistent attempt to encourage a coordinated audience engagement in actions that harmonise with the established shared values and BDS-Australia's strategic mission and moral pursuits. This exhortation is part of the "prognostic framing" task leveraged in public mobilisation (cf. Benford and Snow 2000). Two key tactics are employed to position the audience effectively, which accord with Doran, Martin and Zappavigna's (2024) ways of positioning others in a negotiation of tenor:

- Tendering proposals: This tactic, in all three campaigns, operates by presenting demands or proposing compassionate actions, and seeking a response in the form of negotiated actions and exchanges of what Halliday and Matthiessen (2014) term goods and services.
- Tendering propositions: This tactic provides information that enhances the credibility of exhorted actions in the eyes of the audience. By establishing a strong link between actions of helping victims (or restoring justice) and moralised presentation of experiences, the credibility and value of the actions are reinforced.

The campaigns manifest two patterns of tendering actions. The first is to initially propose specific actions to elicit the audience's response or support (tendering proposals) – as in Example (22) urging Australians to send messages to Puma's CEO and shareholders to condemn Puma's association with Israel's apartheid. Subsequently, propositions are interwoven throughout the campaign to frame the purpose and context of these actions.

(22) **SEND A MESSAGE TO PUMA BEFORE THE AGM[.]**

Send a Message to the CEO[.]

TELL PUMA AND SHAREHOLDERS: END SUPPORT FOR ISRAELI APARTHEID[.]

In the second pattern, the text begins by tendering propositions, offering information about the immoral actions of entities such as Puma, HP and RMIT in support of Israel's apartheid. Following this, exhorted actions (i.e. tendering proposals e.g. "SIGN THE PETITION TO...", in red) and their purpose are established as in Figure 7, creating a context necessitating a response and then constructing the exhorted action as a response to disruption in the established moral order. Through these two patterns of tendering actions that aim to address immoral behaviour by Australians – including Australian institutions (e.g. RMIT), officials

(e.g. Premier of Victoria, Federal Minister for Defence Industry) as in Figure 7, sports clubs in partnership with Puma (e.g. Queensland Maroon, Athletics Australia), and citizens and institutions using HP products – the texts strategically shunt between essentialised identities and universal or broad moral orders and identities. As such, the use of essentialised identities by digital activists here is unlike their employment by extremist groups (far-rightists or jihadists), where the in-group essentialised identities are used as a basis for predispositions and assumptions that inform violent actions and identity relationships and where evaluative couplings are employed in response to signs of disloyalty to the in-group (Etaywe and Zappavigna 2021; Etaywe 2022a, 2022b, 2023a, 2023b, 2024). In the three campaigns, Australians are encouraged to challenge and pressure other Australians and national institutions for violating moral fields that embrace all Australians and other social groups across borders.

• Elbit manufactures or has manufactured **several types of weapons** that are considered controversial or illegal under the laws of war which include weaponized white phosphorus, cluster bombs, and flechette projectiles which the Israeli military has used in various offensives.

• Amnesty International reiterated its call for a **comprehensive arms embargo** of Israel in 2018 as a result of the indiscriminate shooting of unarmed protesters at the Gaza fence using weaponry produced by **IMI**, an Israeli arms manufacturer taken over by Elbit in 2018.

BDS Australia condemns the Victorian state and Federal government's and RMIT University's collaboration with Elbit Systems and Elbit Systems of Australia and calls on all Australians to oppose and take action to stop arms deals and any research and training agreements with Elbit.

SIGN THE PETITION TO:

PAT CONROY MP, FEDERAL MINISTER FOR DEFENSE INDUSTRY
DANIEL ANDREWS, PREMIER OF VICTORIA
RMIT Academic Board Chair – Dr Sharon Andrews
RMIT Professor John Thangarajah

Figure 7. A pattern of tendering propositions followed by tendering a proposal in the “Stop Elbit” campaign

In Bucholtz’s (2003: 407) terms, the texts, by challenging other Australians and Australian institutions’ actions, move from authenticity which “presupposes that identity is primordial” to authentication which views identity as “the outcome of constantly negotiated social practices” in alignment with established collective values. That is, compassionate identity formation is tailored through the negotiation and contestation of moral values and actions “with other social actors and in relation to larger and often unyielding structures of power” (Bucholtz 2003: 408). Authentication by performing, thus, appears to serve to forge relational links and test moral relatability against shared moral fields – in which people act – and moral positions that link social structure to personal or collective agency. That

is, authentication is a tactic of intersubjectivity and negotiation of interpersonal treatment that extends beyond the Australian borders.

While tendering propositions is predominantly realised in statements, tendering proposals is predominantly realised in using the command speech function – including experiential hashtags (Zappavigna 2018) – as in Example (23) (in bold). This command structure positions the BDS activists as a demander of action. That is the author “takes on himself a role [...] and allocates the complementary role [of the executor...] to the [reader]” (Halliday 1973: 56). Demanding an action also means inviting the targeted audience to give – it is an “interact” (Halliday and Matthiessen 2014: 135). The analysis has revealed that these exhorted social actions have two main purposes that reflect what makes these actions meaningful in the eyes of the Palestinians – emphasising Bond et al.’s (2022) argument for the importance of a tangible response that is meaningful in the eyes of those in suffering. Tracking these responses, however, falls beyond the scope of this study. These purposes accord with van Leeuwen’s (2008) purposes of social actions:

- Effect-oriented social actions: The purpose here is focused on the outcome of the exhorted action, which triggers responses beyond the exhorted audience. This purpose can be glossed as follows: “Doing ‘X’ builds or leads to ‘Y’”, or alternatively “We do ‘X’ so that some entity or business does ‘Y’”, as in Example (23) where the effect or outcome is realised in the ‘until-clause’ (underlined).
- Means-oriented social actions: The action here is depicted as a means to an end. The exhorted actions act as a mechanism or pathway to achieve broader objectives. This purpose can be glossed as follows: “We achieve ‘y’ by ‘x’-ing, where ‘x’ serves as a pathway to achieve ‘y’”, as in the “Don’t buy HP” campaign, where BDS-Australia explicitly expresses that various actions of boycott, divestment and sanctions are “*the most effective way to counter Israeli apartheid and settler colonialism*”.

(23) **#BoycottPuma** until PUMA ends support for Israel’s apartheid regime
currently manifested by a far-right racist government supporting settler
militias burning down Palestinian towns.

5. Conclusion and future implications

This study has examined the concept of “compassion” and modelled the development of compassion in digital activist discourse linguistically. Compassion, as

revealed in this study, extends beyond mere emotion (e.g. Ure and Frost 2013), encompassing a semantic domain involving ethics, established collective values and criteria for valuation (i.e. judgment and appreciation). Moreover, compassion has emerged as both a dispositional trait and a performative value. By examining the discourse of compassion in the context of social struggles, this research has contributed to our understanding of resistance projects designed for social change and – as expressed by Hughes (2018:196) – has directed our attention to the moral agency of individuals actively engaged “in reshaping structural constraints” in their resistance against oppression and injustice. In these resistance projects, compassion – akin to Sznajder’s (2015) argument – develops towards an organised, public response to wrongdoing. Akin to research suggesting that digital activism provides a platform for opposing the status quo (Carty 2010; Parsloe and Holton 2018), BDS-Australia seems to offer a space for the targeted audience to access a morally infused counter-narrative, enabling activists to challenge institutionalised power dynamics in the occupied Palestinian territories. Nevertheless, these counter-narratives turn the digital dimension of Palestinian resistance into a subject of concern for Israeli authorities (Monshipouri and Prompichai 2017: 48), making an investigation into the Israeli stance on these campaigns a worthwhile endeavour for future research.

Compassion has been established as an axiological and moral practice, evident in how the campaigns unfold. They unfold rhetorically as inviting individuals to become part of a morally committed community. To foster rationality and achieve this alignment with the target audience, BDS-Australia activists emphasise commonalities with their audience as anti-colonialists while distinguishing themselves from those constructed as pro-colonialists. This involves downplaying differences and accentuating moral similarities that support the pro-Palestinian moral cause. By infusing morality into their campaigns, BDS activists frame their arguments in terms of moral values rather than focusing solely on the actions of the oppressors. Thus, irrespective of government and various individuals’ political stances on the Israeli-Palestinian conflict, activating broad and universal moral values and human rights appears to establish a significant field for institutionalising compassion and encouraging individuals to act compassionately (cf. Sznajder 2015).

The language used in the texts has been found to serve two primary functions. First, it functions as a means of *communication*, employed to raise awareness about human suffering and immoral actions, events and experiences in which the targeted entities are complicit. Through the presentation of propositions, these campaigns construct a moral quest, an enlightenment aimed at raising awareness among the target audience. This enlightenment is fuelled by the understanding that learning about others’ experiences plays a pivotal role in cultivating compas-

sion and activating individuals' "proactive form of moral agency" (Bandura 2016: 92). Second, language functions as a means of *communion*, an immediate end in itself (cf. Nist, 1966: 51). It is used in the "promotion, establishment, and maintenance of communion [or a sense of shared] feeling" (Firth 1964: 112), forging a sense of alignment with others in a pro-victim affiliation. The act of positioning others through the presentation of proposals and propositions reveals the negotiation and contestation of values as commodity motifs, and exhorted actions as verbal and non-verbal commodities. The exhorted engagement with the audience appears to align with Bandura's (2016) dual aspects of moral agency, encompassing:

- proactive moral agency – encouraging acts of compassion.
- inhibitive moral agency – discouraging immoral behaviour.

The texts also portray these social actions of engagement as being means- and effect-oriented, thus serving as facilitators for alleviating suffering and achieving BDS's strategic mission.

Establishing shared bonds to support these campaigns has been found to provide legitimacy and foster rational commitment to acts of help, even at the risk of contagion for those who open themselves up to the suffering of others. BDS-Australia activists constantly enact bonding and negotiate both similarities and differences to achieve "axiological proximization" (Cap 2017: 17), thereby legitimising their cause. However, while Cap suggests that axiological proximisation involves a clash between in-group and out-group members, this study highlights the use of axiological proximisation as a discursive strategy to assist activists in:

- presenting remote events and ideologies as consequential to the audience's passive responses to disruptions in shared norms and moral orders.
- construing a clash between people's, including in-group's, "appropriate" and "inappropriate" behaviours in the pursuit of maintaining the moral order (e.g. Kádár 2017).

This disruption in moral order as well as the consequential harmful events construes the disrupters as morally deviant social actors, a deviance that calls for compassion (Silver and Abell 2016). In the Durkheimian sense, deviance also affirms shared values, accentuates moral boundaries, encourages people to come together and react in a coordinated way against deviant behaviours and leads to social change (Macionis and Gerber 2010).

Framing plays a pivotal role in fostering compassion in digital activism by intertwining acts of compassion with the challenge and contestation of knowledge schema, ideas, meanings and values. Engagement in shaping master frames like human rights, care, freedom, injustice, unethical research collaboration and racial

discrimination achieves two goals: portraying digital activists as moral agents who build consensus and cultural resonance with their audience; and establishing a “reality of deontology... that confers rights, responsibilities, and so on” (Searle 2010: 89). By activating inclusive master frames, shared moral fields and tendering calls to actions, the audience is positioned with certain expectations regarding their responses of compassion and moral obligations to intervene (e.g. Van Langenhove 2017).

For a fuller understanding of the role of digital activist campaigns in cultivating compassion, future studies should delve into intermodal couplings and multimodality to explore how visuals, hyperlinks and hashtags complement verbal communication, enhancing our understanding of the negotiation of morality and the enactment of compassion within digital activism. Additionally, future research can investigate how appraisal resources are utilised in self-presentation as a compassionate individual or entity. Deploying further linguistic research in the service of advancing social justice and compassion is vital. Put in Mandela’s (1997: np) terms, through cultivating “acts of compassion, we can keep the flames of solidarity, justice, and freedom burning”, bearing witness to the authentic humanity of individuals, as well as fostering mutual respect and trust.

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Address for correspondence

Awni Etaywe
Faculty of Arts and Society
Charles Darwin University
Ellengowan Dr
Casuarina NT 0810
Australia
awni.etaywe@cdu.edu.au
 <https://orcid.org/0000-0001-6518-6158>

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